



SHASHI SHEKAR KASHYAP

Player to watch out for **ABHISHEK**

The 26-year-old from Haryana has been on fire for India over the past 18 months, emerging as the undisputed spearhead of the attack. Among Asia's quickest players, this Sonipat speedster blends raw pace with flair, a nightmare combination for any defender. Even during India's faltering Pro League campaign, Abhishek stood out as a beacon of hope — his numbers tell the story: 42 goals in just 106 appearances. With Lalit Upadhyay's retirement, the burden on his shoulders has grown heavier, but he seems more than ready. A natural poacher with a sharp sense of positioning, Abhishek has an uncanny ability to turn the smallest of openings into match-winning opportunities.

share top-scorer honours with Abhishek, injuries since the Paris Olympics have hampered him. With Amit Rohidas, Jugraj Singh, and Sanjay unable to replicate his threat, India faces hard questions about set-piece strategy.

"When Harmanpreet isn't on the field, do we need to re-examine our penalty corner routines? Can more variations ease the pressure on him and the rest of the team?" the piece asks. Fulton insists patience is key. "We get an average of 5-6 penalty corners a game, sometimes even more. We have a few other drag-flickers who are still learning and need more exposure to convert those chances. We always practice variations; it is all about how we use them."

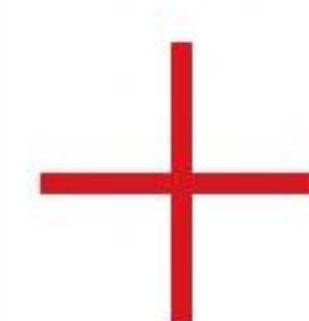
Goalkeeping concerns

The Pro League also exposed frailties in goal. Krishan Pathak struggled with aerial balls, a weakness ruthlessly exploited by tall European forwards. Suraj Karkera looked sharper but faltered in pressure moments. With defensive lapses leaving them exposed, forwards were forced to shoulder more responsibility.

"Forwards are the first line of defence," explained Abhishek. "I've had to become much more switched on when we don't have the ball. It's all about giving our defenders more cover and perfectly executing our man-to-man strategy."

Course correction

India has since regrouped with a four-week camp at the Sports



India's Asia Cup record

Titles: 3 (2003, 2007, 2017)

Runner-up: 5 (1982, 1985, 1989, 1994, 2013)

Third place: 2 (1999, 2022)

India has won 43 out of 56 matches in the Asia Cup and holds the record for most wins in the competition.